REPUBLIC OF BOTSWANA

MINISTRY OF ENVIRONMENT AND TOURISM

Insect of the Month

December 2025



Winged Termites

Forder: Blattodea
Infraorder: Isoptera

Meet the Alates (winged termites)

Winter being a distant memory, the summer rains have once again nourished the ground with much needed moisture and in turn triggering a remarkable natural event- the emergence of the Alates ***(winged termites).*** Yes! those very same annoying insects that are always on our doorsteps and shedding their wings all over the place after it rains.

Their appearance serves as an ecological indicator of seasonal change and more importantly a significant phase in a termites' life cycle. Alates time their swarming flights with the first rains, seizing the window of increased humidity and soft earth to mate, disperse and establish the next generation of termite colonies. Because of their appearance after the first rains, most people use their sighting as a mark for the beginning of the agricultural season.

Description and Importance

Known as the sexually mature reproductive caste of termites, Alates are easily noticed by their wings and darkly pigmented body. Alates have two pairs of long, equal-sized wings that extend way beyond their abdomen which are ideal for their swarming flights. Once they land and pair with a mate, Alates shed their wings and transition into primary ***queens and kings.*** Though often misunderstood and considered an annoyance especially after it rains, Alates play crucial ecological roles:

- **Improved soil health** – by tunneling through the soil to make new colonies these insects improve soil aeration and nutrient turnover.
- **Decomposers** - they carry out the decomposition of dead organic matter thanks to symbiotic gut microorganisms.
- **Source of food** - Alates support the ecological food chain, serving as food for birds, reptiles, fish etc.

Fun Facts

Did you know that Alates are considered a delicacy in some cultures around the world?.

OPENING HOURS
Monday to Friday 0730 - 1800hrs
Saturday and Sunday 0730 - 1800hrs
Public Holiday 0800 - 1800hrs

BOTSWANA national museum

national botanical garden

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